ON APRIL 12, 1962, THE DAY AFTER THE PUBLICATION OF THE *Pravda* editorial, the Presidium of the Central Committee, the USSR's governing body under the leadership of Nikita Khrushchev, approved a set of urgent measures to help Fidel Castro and his government. The Presidium decreed to expedite delivery to Cuba of 180 antiaircraft surface-to-air missiles requested by Castro in September 1961. He was also to get Sopka air-to-surface cruise missiles developed on the basis of the Soviet MiG-15 fighter for use as an anti-ship weapon. Some of the missiles that the Presidium decided to send to Cuba were taken from the quota already promised to another Soviet client in the Third World, Prime Minister Gamal Abdel Nasser of Egypt. Cuba was given priority over Egypt in the Soviet pecking order.

When it came to missiles, Moscow was still sending fewer than Castro had asked for, but he was also offered something he had not requested: ten Ilyushin-28 medium bombers and four R-15 cruise-missile launchers. By cutting back on some of Castro's requests while offering other weapons and equipment instead, the Presidium was not trying to save money. It wanted to better prepare Cuba to repel a possible invasion; to that end, bombers were no less important than missiles. Besides arms, members of the Soviet military would be coming to Cuba: 650 officers, sergeants, and soldiers to operate the launchers, pilot the planes, and teach the Cubans how to do both.[17]

The cost of the missiles and other equipment to be sent to Cuba on the basis of the Presidium's decision of April 12 was 23 million rubles. That was coming on the top of an already impressive military aid package. The USSR had begun to supply arms to Cuba back in 1960, and by May 1962 agreements worth 228 million rubles had been signed. Armaments worth 142 million rubles had already been delivered to Havana. Some were donated, others offered at a discount, and still others sold at their regular price by means of a line of credit extended to Cuba. In 1962 Cuba was expected to pay the USSR up to 50 million rubles for armaments already received, but the crisis-stricken country had no money to do so, let alone to afford new shipments.

Khrushchev decided not only to write off Cuba's debt for the armaments supplied earlier but also to supply new armaments free of charge for the next two years, regardless of quantity and cost. The USSR also agreed to